## Napoleonic Europe

By the end of the 18th century, Europe had experienced the French Revolution give way into the Thermidorian Reaction. It was then that one of the greatest European military leaders stamped his mark on history. In 1799, Napoleon Bonaparte was elected as head of the Consulate and led France to become one of the superpowers of the day. Under Napoleon, the French crushed domestic uprisings, seized lands within Italy and campaigned against other nations. In 1801, Napoleon forged new relationships with the Church and restructured the laws in France through the Napoleonic Code. Three years later, Napoleon had amassed enough power to declare himself as Emperor.

Napoleon grew stronger with each victory. The European powers kept attacking him, one after the other, but all were defeated. He won Marengo in 1800 with other victories five and seven years later. In 1807, Czar Alexander I had no choice but to forge an alliance with him by signing the Treaty of Tilsit. Napoleon went on to establish numerous states that were loyal to him and eventually had dominion over much of Europe. The ideas of the French Revolution influenced anyone who met him or had a discussion with him. The only battle he lost was the Battle of Trafalgar against the British navy, which occurred at the turn of the century.

Britain was one of a few countries that posed a threat to Napoleon. To solve this problem, he imposed the Continental System in 1806. It was intended to prevent Britain from being able to trade with the rest of Europe but the plan backfired and Napoleon faced the consequences instead. Firstly, German nationalism began due to ideas sparked by the French emperor. Secondly, the Continental System resulted in the Peninsular War in Spain, which caused the French army to be diverted away from the rest of the continent.

Napoleon’s wife Josephine was abandoned in 1810 because she had not given him a child. He replaced her with the younger Marie Louise of Austria. Together, they produced a son who they planned to call the King of Rome. For a time, they were a happy family until the Russian czar pulled